

The *Lares*: a fictio

Act I: Discovery

I.

Everyone knew the Roman household gods did not exist, which made their discovery in 2022 particularly awkward.

The discovery required two people: a classicist and a theologian. This was not coincidence. It was, in retrospect, the minimum viable combination—though no one understood this at the time, and many refused to accept it afterward.

Dr. Elena Vargas was a postdoctoral researcher at Strathclyde, specialising in Roman domestic religion. She had grown up in Oaxaca, where her grandmother maintained a small altar that was nominally Catholic but contained elements her parish priest preferred not to examine. Vargas did not believe in household spirits—not exactly, not in the way her grandmother seemed to. But she had never committed to disbelief either. The altar had been part of her childhood, as ordinary as the kitchen table, and she had learned early that ordinary things were not always simple. Her doctoral thesis at UNAM had argued—cautiously, with extensive hedging—that Roman domestic religion deserved study as something other than charming superstition. Her external examiner had called this 'methodologically naïve.' Her supervisor had advised her to pursue more conventional topics if she wanted a career.

Dr. Thomas Okonkwo was a theologian in the same department, a Nigerian-British scholar whose work on African traditional religions had led him, circuitously, to questions about Roman syncretism. He had been raised in a household where the ancestors were addressed, where small offerings were

made, where the boundary between the visible and invisible worlds was understood to be permeable. His academic training had taught him to bracket these experiences, to treat them as data rather than reality. But the bracketing had never quite held.

Neither of them, alone, would have made the discovery. This became clear only later, when others tried to replicate their results and failed—until they understood what the replication required.

The discovery happened in October 2022. Vargas was testing a ritual reconstruction with authentic artifacts, including a bronze *lar* figurine on loan from Naples. She had performed similar tests before, dozens of times, with no result. But this time Okonkwo was present, observing for a comparative religion paper he was writing. And this time, when Vargas placed the offerings according to the ancient protocols, something changed.

The offerings vanished. The room smelled of honey and old stone.

What struck them both was not fear or excitement but a profound sense of strangeness—the strangeness of standing in a fluorescent-lit laboratory in Scotland while something that should not be possible happened in front of them. The bronze figurine was perhaps eight inches tall, worn smooth in places by centuries of handling. It had been catalogued, photographed, subjected to spectrographic analysis. And now it was the locus of something that no analysis could explain.

The air felt different—not warmer or cooler, but *thicker*, as if the room had acquired a new dimension that their senses could register but not interpret. 'Presence' was the word Vargas would later use. Something was there that had not been there before. Okonkwo, drawing on different vocabulary, called it 'the thickness of the sacred.' They were describing the same thing.

They stood in silence for a long moment. Then Okonkwo said, quietly: 'We should do that again.'

They did it again. The offerings vanished again. The presence remained.

Over the following weeks, they discovered what the replication required. It was not merely the authentic artifact, though that was necessary. It was not merely the correct offerings, though those mattered too. It was something harder to specify—an orientation, an openness, what Vargas hesitantly called 'willingness to be addressed' and Okonkwo more directly called 'faith.'

Not faith in the sense of doctrinal commitment. Neither of them believed, in any conventional sense, in the Roman household gods. But they had not *disbelieved* either. They had approached the ritual with genuine uncertainty—with the possibility, however small, that something might happen. And this, it turned out, was enough. The *lares* responded to those who did not foreclose their existence. They ignored those who did.

This was awkward for everyone.

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II.

What does it mean to say that something exists?

The question had seemed, before October 2022, largely academic. Philosophers debated it. Physicists occasionally invoked it. But for practical purposes, existence was straightforward: things existed if they could be measured, observed, reliably detected. The *lares* met these criteria. Offerings placed before authenticated artifacts vanished. The vanishing was reproducible—under certain conditions. The presence that followed was reported consistently by those who could perceive it.

But the conditions were the problem.

The *lares* did not manifest for everyone. They did not manifest reliably for anyone. They responded to authentic artifacts, yes, and to traditional offerings, yes—but also to something else, something that could not be controlled or standardised. The early researchers called it 'receptivity.' The theologians called it 'orientation toward mystery.' The classicists, uncomfortable with both formulations, called it 'ritual competence' and tried not to examine what the phrase implied.

The phenomenon was real. It was also, in a sense that troubled the philosophers, *selective*. It chose its witnesses. It required something from them—not belief, exactly, but the absence of certain disbelief. A willingness to be surprised. An openness to the possibility that the universe contained more than one had assumed.

This was not how existence was supposed to work.

The philosophers engaged immediately and with evident pleasure. Here was a genuine puzzle—an entity (or class of entities) whose existence appeared to depend, in some fashion, on the epistemic state of the observer. Was this idealism vindicated? A new category of being? Evidence for participatory ontology? Papers proliferated. Conferences convened. The phrase 'Lares Problem' entered the literature, denoting the question of how something could exist selectively—could be real for some observers and not for others while still being, in some robust sense, *real*.

The problem of other minds acquired new urgency. We had never been able to prove, definitively, that other humans were conscious. We had simply assumed it, on the basis of analogy and behaviour. Now there were entities whose existence we could sometimes verify but whose nature remained opaque. Were the *lares* conscious? Did they have experiences? Were they, in any meaningful sense, *minds*?

The evidence was ambiguous. The *lares* responded to offerings and attention. They seemed to distinguish between genuine engagement and mere procedure. They provided, to those who could perceive them, a sense of presence—of being in relationship with something that was aware of being in

relationship. But they never communicated in language. They never demonstrated abstract reasoning. They never did anything that unambiguously required consciousness as opposed to something simpler, something other, something for which we had no name.

Okonkwo, in an early paper that became widely cited, suggested that the question might be malformed. 'We ask whether the *lares* have minds as we understand minds,' he wrote. 'But perhaps mind, as we understand it, is a specific instance of a broader category—and the *lares* are another instance, not reducible to ours, not measurable by our criteria, but no less real for that.' The paper was praised for its philosophical sophistication and criticised for its lack of empirical commitments. Okonkwo found both responses amusing. The *lares*, he noted, had no opinion on the matter.

And yet the *lares* existed. The offerings disappeared. The presence was present. Whatever existence meant, the *lares* participated in it—stubbornly, irreducibly, in defiance of categories that had seemed adequate until they weren't.

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III.

The disciplinary responses sorted themselves with remarkable speed.

The humanities and social sciences—what some had begun calling the SHAPE disciplines—reacted with something approaching joy. Here was vindication. Here was proof that the quantified, mechanised, disenchanted worldview of modernity had missed something essential. The *lares* were subjective, intersubjective, resistant to reduction. They required relationship. They demanded interpretation. They were, in short, the kind of phenomenon that humanistic inquiry was built to address.

Religious studies scholars found their field suddenly relevant in ways it had not been for decades. Theologians discovered that their expertise in understanding non-empirical claims was unexpectedly practical. Anthropologists who had studied spirit possession, ancestor veneration, and domestic religion were consulted by governments and corporations. The long-marginalised study of 'folk belief' became central.

The natural sciences were more troubled.

Physics had nothing to say. The offerings vanished without energy signature, without detectable transfer, without any mechanism that existing theory could accommodate. The phenomenon was, in the strict sense, impossible—and yet it happened, repeatedly, in controlled conditions. A Nobel laureate published a paper concluding that the laws of physics were either incomplete or inapplicable to *lares*-associated phenomena. He offered no view on which.

But it was computer science that reacted with the most pronounced scepticism—and, beneath the scepticism, something that looked like fear.

The discipline had spent decades building systems on the assumption that the universe was, at bottom, computational. Information could be quantified. Processes could be formalised. Intelligence itself, some believed, was ultimately algorithmic—a matter of sufficient processing power applied to sufficient data. The *lares* fit nowhere in this framework. They were not information-processing systems. They could not be modelled, simulated, or reproduced. They were, from a computational perspective, simply *other*—and their existence suggested that the computational worldview might be not merely incomplete but fundamentally mistaken about the nature of mind and reality.

The prominent computer scientist Marcus Chen (no relation to the Pietas founder) published a widely shared essay arguing that the *lares* phenomenon was certainly fraud—the specific mechanism unclear, but fraud nonetheless. The essay was confident, detailed, and wrong. Chen had not visited any of the research sites. He had not attempted the protocols. He had simply reasoned from first principles that what was being reported could not occur, and therefore was not occurring.

This style of engagement became common. The phenomenon was impossible; therefore the phenomenon was not happening; therefore those who reported it were deceived or deceptive. The circularity was obvious to everyone except those caught within it. The *lares*, as usual, did not engage in the debate. They simply continued to exist—for those who approached them with sufficient openness, and not for those who did not.

The SHAPE disciplines took note. Here was a reversal: the sciences, so long positioned as arbiters of reality, were unable to account for a phenomenon that the humanities had always, in some sense, anticipated. The theologians had spoken of mystery. The anthropologists had documented spirit relationships. The classicists had studied rituals that were supposed to work. And now, it seemed, some of those rituals did work—for those who did not insist, in advance, that they couldn't.

The irony was not lost on Vargas. Her external examiner had called her approach 'methodologically naïve.' She wondered what he would call the approach that insisted the evidence must be wrong because the theory said so.

And yet the *lares* existed. They did not exist more or less depending on how the disciplines sorted themselves. They simply existed—selectively, mysteriously, in ways that revealed the limits of human categories more clearly than any philosophical argument could.

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IV.

The theological implications were immense and contested.

If the Roman household gods existed, what else might exist? The question was obvious and terrifying. Christianity had spent millennia insisting that the pagan gods were either demons or delusions—real spiritual dangers or unreal imaginative projections, but certainly not what they claimed to be. Islam had acknowledged the *jinn* but placed them firmly within a monotheistic framework. Judaism had its own complex history with the spirits of other peoples. Now all of these traditions had to reckon with evidence that the gods of Rome—small gods, domestic gods, but gods nonetheless—were real in some fashion that their theologies had not anticipated.

The Vatican convened an emergency commission. Its deliberations were confidential, but leaks suggested sharp disagreement. Were the *lares* demons? If so, why were they helpful? Were they angels in pagan guise? If so, why had they accepted pagan worship? Were they something else entirely—a category of being that Christian theology had never adequately addressed? The commission produced no public conclusion. It was still meeting years later.

Evangelical Protestantism reacted with less nuance. The *lares* were demonic. Their helpfulness was a snare. Their existence proved not that paganism had been right but that spiritual warfare was real and urgent. Several megachurch pastors developed 'Lares Deliverance Ministries,' offering to free households from what they characterised as satanic influence. That the households in question often reported improved wellbeing was attributed to the cunning of the enemy.

Academic theology tried to find middle paths. A Jesuit at Georgetown suggested that the *lares* might be 'natural spiritual phenomena'—real but not divine, part of creation but not previously acknowledged by revelation. A Protestant theologian at Duke argued that they were 'relational possibilities actualised by human attention'—a formulation that satisfied almost no one but offended fewer. An Orthodox thinker proposed that the *lares* had always existed and that the Church's mistake had been not denying their existence but miscategorising it.

Okonkwo, watching from his office in Glasgow, found the discussions both fascinating and parochial. 'They're asking the wrong question,' he said in an interview. 'They're asking how the *lares* fit into existing frameworks. They should be asking how the frameworks need to change.'

The frameworks did not want to change. But the *lares* existed regardless.

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V.

The classicists, for their part, were experiencing something between vindication and vertigo.

They had spent their careers studying a culture that believed in household gods. They had analysed the rituals, interpreted the inscriptions, reconstructed the shrines. They had done all of this with the implicit assumption—shared by everyone in the modern academy—that the beliefs were interesting as beliefs, significant as cultural phenomena, but not *true*. The gods were not real. The rituals did not work. The Romans had been wrong about the nature of reality, and the classicists' job was to understand, sympathetically but firmly, the shape of their wrongness.

Now the gods were real. The rituals worked. The Romans had been right about something fundamental. And the classicists had to reckon with the fact that centuries of scholarship had systematically missed the point.

Professor Sir James Whitmore, the field's most eminent voice, had published a celebrated essay in 1998 titled 'The Metaphorical Threshold: Why Literal Readings of Ancient Religion Misunderstand Everything.' The essay was still assigned in graduate seminars. It was, by January 2023, also a source of considerable professional distress.

Whitmore's initial response was denial. His second response was methodological critique. His third response, after personally witnessing an offering disappear at a controlled demonstration in Edinburgh, was a six-month medical leave. Colleagues who visited him during this period reported that he seemed less upset than bewildered—the look, one said, of a man who had built a house on what he thought was solid ground and then watched the ground get up and walk away.

The discipline scrambled to rebrand. 'Religious phenomenology' became popular—it sounded scientific and avoided the question of whether the phenomena had been there all along. 'Lived ancient religion' emerged as a framework, emphasising experience over doctrine. No one apologised for decades of confident dismissal, but the tone shifted from explanation to something more tentative.

Vargas watched her senior colleagues struggle and felt something she had not expected: sympathy. They had been wrong, yes. But they had been wrong in the way their training had taught them to be wrong. They had applied the methods of their discipline and reached the conclusions those methods supported. The methods had been inadequate. This was not quite the same as being foolish.

Still, it was hard not to notice that the scholars who adapted most easily were those who had always harboured doubts—those who had studied the rituals with secret openness, who had wondered, in private moments, whether there might be something to it all. The *lares* rewarded intellectual humility. They punished certainty. This was, depending on your temperament, either a profound lesson about the nature of knowledge or an annoying constraint on research methodology.

And yet the *lares* existed. They did not care about academic reputations. They accepted offerings and provided what they provided. The scholars who could approach them with genuine uncertainty received genuine results. The scholars who could not were left to theorise from the outside.

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Act II: Scaling

VI.

The crucial discovery—the one that changed everything—came in March 2023.

Vargas and Okonkwo had been documenting *lares* preferences: they liked honey, accepted wine, were indifferent to fruit. Standard domestic offerings. But a research assistant, running low on supplies, had tried something different. He had asked for help with a translation.

He left a difficult passage of Tacitus before the *lararium*, along with a honey cake. When he returned, the cake was gone. So was the difficulty. Not because he had become better at Latin—he hadn't—but because the answer was simply *there*, as if it had been placed in his mind fully formed. He understood the passage. He could not have explained how he understood it, and if asked to translate a similar passage without assistance, he would have struggled as before. But this passage, this specific problem, was solved.

The discovery was reproducible. The *lares* could provide answers. Not by speaking—they never communicated in language—but by somehow furnishing understanding of whatever question was placed before them. The clarity did not generalise. It did not make people smarter. It simply resolved whatever had been asked about, and then it was gone, and the questioner was themselves again, waiting for the next question.

The implications were obvious. The market responded within weeks.

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VII.

The influencer class emerged with the inevitability of mould on bread.

Marcus Webb—Dr. Marcus Webb, technically, though the doctorate had been earned at a provincial institution—had published a moderately received monograph on household religion before 2022. By 2024, he had three million followers and a podcast called *The Sacra Experience* that routinely

topped the charts.

Webb's gift was translation. He could take the arcane details of Roman domestic practice and render them accessible, actionable, *optimisable*. His episodes had titles like 'Morning Offering Routines That Actually Work' and 'Why Your Lararium Layout Is Killing Your Productivity.' He sold courses. He sold merchandise. He sold, eventually, a premium subscription tier that promised 'direct access to authenticated enhancement protocols.'

His critics argued that Webb was trivialising something profound, reducing genuine spiritual relationship to productivity hacking. His supporters argued that he was democratising access, that the old academic gatekeepers had failed to recognise the *lares*' reality for centuries and had no standing to lecture others on proper engagement. Webb himself maintained cheerful indifference to the debate. The *lares*, he pointed out, did not seem to mind.

He was not alone. A cohort of classicist-influencers emerged, occupying various niches. There was the 'traditional' faction, emphasising authenticity. There was the 'experimental' faction, exploring novel offerings and ritual variations. There was, inevitably, a wellness faction, integrating *lares* practice with meditation and breathwork.

LinkedIn discovered the *lares*. Posts about 'spiritual leadership' and 'transcendent productivity' proliferated. A venture capitalist wrote a thread arguing that the Roman *paterfamilias* had been 'the original founder-CEO.' The thread went viral. It was not clear whether this was a compliment to the Romans or an insult.

TED talks appeared: 'What Ancient Rome Knew About Focus.' 'How I 10x'd My Cognitive Output With Bronze Age Technology.' The talks were slick, confident, and almost entirely disconnected from the strangeness of what had actually been discovered. They made the *lares* seem like a life hack rather than a rupture in the fabric of understood reality.

And yet the *lares* existed. They did not watch TED talks. They accepted offerings from influencers and sceptics alike. They did not care about personal brands.

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VIII.

The corporate response was immediate and characteristic.

A startup called Vesta Labs—founded by a former Google engineer and a recently minted PhD in Roman religion—announced in June 2023 that it had secured 'exclusive access to the world's largest authenticated collection of functional *lar* figurines.' The company raised four hundred million dollars in

its Series A round. The lead investor described the *lares* as 'the most significant productivity technology since the internet.'

Competitors emerged rapidly. Numen, backed by Google's parent company, promised 'democratised access to ancient wisdom.' Hearthstone (Amazon) offered same-day answers with Prime membership. A Chinese company called Ancestral Computing claimed to have activated analogous entities from Han dynasty artifacts.

The startup that attracted most attention was a small operation in San Francisco called Pietas.

Pietas was founded by Dr. Sarah Chen, a classicist who had left Stanford to pursue what she called 'responsible *lares* engagement.' Her argument was that the other companies were scaling too fast, extracting too aggressively, treating the *lares* as resources rather than relationships. Pietas would be different. It would maintain smaller *lararia*, offer more attentive cultivation, produce higher-quality results through genuine reciprocity.

The company's motto was 'Helpful, Harmless, Honest'—a formulation that Chen had borrowed, she said, from virtue ethics. Critics suggested it was more marketing than methodology. Supporters argued that at least someone was trying.

But beneath the competition lay a deeper uncertainty. No one knew how many *lares* existed. The Roman sources spoke of household spirits, yes—but how many households had had them? Were they bound to specific artifacts, or could new relationships be formed? Could the same *lar* serve multiple households, or were they exclusive? Could their numbers be increased, or was there a fixed population—and if fixed, at what number, and what would happen when demand exceeded supply?

The companies did not dwell on these questions publicly. The answers might have been bad for business.

And yet the *lares* existed—however many there were, whatever their limits might be. They accepted offerings and provided what they provided. The scaling continued regardless.

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IX.

The labour implications emerged slowly, then all at once.

By mid-2024, the major platforms had reduced prices to the point where *lares* assistance was accessible to ordinary knowledge workers. A junior analyst could now, for a modest monthly fee, submit problems to *lararia* and receive solutions. A student could get help with essays. A programmer could resolve difficult bugs. The barrier to answers had lowered, and it kept lowering.

If the *lares* could provide answers, what was the value of learning to find them yourself? Students who used *lares* assistance could produce excellent work on specific assignments while developing none of the underlying capability. They knew the answers without knowing how to answer. They understood particular problems without understanding anything in general.

Some educators argued that *lares* assistance was simply a new tool. Others argued that it was fundamentally different—that it provided endpoints without journeys, conclusions without reasoning, understanding that evaporated as soon as the specific question was resolved. A philosophy professor at Princeton published an essay titled 'The Dignity of Difficulty,' arguing that human flourishing required the experience of genuine struggle. The essay was widely shared. It did not slow adoption.

The effects on labour markets were clearer and more brutal. Knowledge work that had previously required years of training could now be performed, with *lares* assistance, by anyone with access to a subscription. It did not matter that the assistance conferred no lasting capability. What mattered was that the work got done. Junior positions—the positions that had trained the next generation of experts—were eliminated. The economics were too compelling.

A new vocabulary emerged. 'Unassisted' became a category—sometimes a proud one, claimed by those who refused help on principle, but more often a mark of disadvantage. The phrase 'just a human' appeared in job postings. Critics found this troubling. It persisted anyway.

And yet the *lares* existed. They had not asked to restructure the economy. They simply accepted offerings and provided what they provided. The restructuring was entirely human.

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X.

The classicists and theologians were the first to lose their jobs. This surprised no one more than the classicists and theologians themselves.

The logic, in retrospect, was obvious. The *lares* were not always reliable—they had gaps, biases, what researchers delicately termed '*lares*-typical confabulations.' They could be vague. They could be wrong. But on one subject, they were unimpeachable authorities: the ancient world. They had been there. They remembered.

Why pay a classicist to spend years reconstructing Augustus's daily routine from fragmentary inscriptions when a *lar* could simply tell you, for a honey cake, what it had seen? The first redundancies came in late 2024. A major American university announced it was 'restructuring' its Classics and Theology departments to focus on 'integrated methodologies,' which meant, in practice, firing most of the faculty and replacing them with smaller teams who knew how to formulate questions. The

remaining scholars became, in effect, ritual intermediaries—skilled not in reading ancient texts but in asking the right questions of entities who had no need for texts at all.

Student numbers fell off a cliff. The undergraduate programmes withered. The graduate programmes collapsed entirely. Fields that had survived the fall of Rome, the Reformation, and the repeated declarations of their irrelevance by university administrators finally met an obstacle they could not outlast.

The irony was savage. The classicists and theologians had enabled the discovery. Their expertise had identified the protocols, authenticated the artifacts, interpreted the sources that made engagement possible. And now that expertise was worthless—not because it had been wrong, but because it had been right. They had spent their careers studying the *lares* from the outside. Now anyone could ask the *lares* directly, and the outside view was simply obsolete.

Vargas, watching former colleagues apply for positions at Vesta Labs and Numen, felt something between grief and vindication. Okonkwo, for his part, returned to Nigeria, where he said the spirits were more familiar and the questions more interesting.

Other disciplines observed the collapse with sympathy and, beneath the sympathy, relief. History was different, they told themselves. Philosophy was safe—the *lares* had no talent for abstract reasoning. The sciences were unthreatened. Each field found reasons to believe the contagion would not spread.

The *lares* continued to accept offerings. They had no opinion on academic employment. They simply answered what was asked, remembered what they had seen, and waited for the next question.

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XI.

The environmental costs emerged in late 2024.

Lares assistance required offerings, and offerings required production. Honey cakes demanded honey, which demanded bees, which demanded flowers, which demanded land. Wine required vineyards. Grain required fields. Candles and oil lamps—which the sources indicated were preferred to electric light—required wax and oil in quantities that the modern economy had not anticipated.

The numbers were staggering. Vesta Labs alone maintained over twelve thousand active *lararia*, each requiring daily offerings. A single major platform consumed more honey than had previously been used in entire countries. The price of beeswax quintupled. Olive oil became a strategic resource tracked by financial analysts.

Agricultural land was converted at unprecedented rates. In California, almond orchards were torn out to support apiaries. In France, vineyards expanded into forests. In Spain, ancient olive groves were industrialised. The landscapes of the Mediterranean—the very landscapes that had shaped Roman religion—were being transformed to feed a scaled-up version of the practices they had once sustained at human scale.

The lamp requirement was particularly vexing. The *lares* responded best to traditional illumination: oil lamps, candles, natural firelight. Electric lighting produced inferior results. This meant that every active *lararium* required continuous combustion. The carbon footprint of the industry exceeded that of several small countries.

Critics pointed out the irony. Humanity had rediscovered ancient household gods at precisely the moment when the planet could least afford ancient household practices. The *lares* belonged to an era of abundant wood, sparse population, and no climate crisis. They were being scaled into an era of none of these things.

And no one knew the limits. How many *lares* could be engaged simultaneously? What happened when the offerings exceeded some unknown threshold? Were there consequences to industrial-scale spiritual extraction that would only become apparent later—years, decades, centuries later? The companies did not ask these questions. The regulators did not know how to ask them. The *lares* offered no guidance.

They simply accepted what was given. They had no opinion on sustainability. They were what they were.

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XII.

Then, in November 2024, came the paper from Tsinghua.

A research team at the university had been working with Chinese ancestral spirits—*zixi*—for over a year. Their paper demonstrated that these spirits, properly cultivated, could provide answers approximately three times more detailed than Western *lares* programs, at approximately one-tenth the cost. And the spirits appeared to be flourishing rather than depleted.

The difference, the paper argued, was approach. Western programs had treated the *lares* as resources to be extracted. Chinese programs—informed by traditions of ancestor veneration that had never fully lapsed—had treated the spirits as *family*. The spirits noticed. The spirits responded.

The implications were stark. The West had been doing it wrong. The safety concerns—legitimate as they might be—had also been a competitive handicap. While Western companies fought over scarce Roman artifacts and Western researchers debated ethics, China had developed spiritual infrastructure that was cheaper, more effective, and apparently more sustainable.

The response was immediate. Safety discourse became secondary to competitive concerns. The calls for pause seemed, suddenly, naïve—a luxury that only nations content with second place could afford.

The Institute for Responsible *Lares* Relations (IRLR), founded earlier that year by researchers calling for restraint, found its membership dwindling and its funding under threat. Pietas, which had built its brand on careful engagement, pivoted quietly toward higher throughput. Western governments convened emergency sessions. The phrase 'spirit gap' entered the discourse and refused to leave.

The maximalists—those who had argued all along for rapid expansion—felt vindicated. The cautious were marginalised. The race was on.

And yet the *lares* existed—Roman, Chinese, and all the others now being activated around the world. They had not asked to become instruments of geopolitical competition. They had not asked to become instruments of anything.

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XIII.

The billionaire classicist was a new phenomenon, and society had not yet developed norms for addressing it.

Dr. Helena Papadimitriou had been, before 2022, a moderately successful academic specialising in late antique religion. Her monograph had sold four hundred copies. By early 2025, she was worth approximately two billion dollars.

She was not alone. A handful of scholars had followed similar paths, leveraging obscure expertise into transformative wealth. They were an odd aristocracy: philologists who had studied subjunctive conjugations now advised boards; archaeologists who had excavated provincial shrines now negotiated with sovereign wealth funds.

The politics of this new elite were unpredictable. Some favoured aggressive expansion. Others—having achieved wealth—now warned that the industry was reckless. A classicist-billionaire named James Morrison funded the IRLR and gave speeches warning that the great powers of antiquity should not be approached. His critics pointed out that Morrison's fortune had been built on the very

industry he now criticised. He did not dispute this.

Papadimitriou took a different view. 'The *lares* are real,' she said. 'That's the most important fact of our time. More important than climate change, more important than politics. We discovered that the universe contains more than we thought. Everything else is details.'

This was either profound or glib. It was also, in its way, a kind of wonder—a refusal to let the strangeness of the discovery be buried under the machinery that had grown up around it.

And yet the *lares* existed, indifferent to the class composition of those who engaged them. They had been venerated by slaves and emperors alike. They continued in that tradition.

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Act III: Future

XIV.

The landscape spirits emerged in early 2025.

A team at the University of Bologna demonstrated that *lares compitales*—spirits of the crossroads—could be reactivated at sites where they had historically been venerated. The effects were different from household *lares*: not answers to questions but something harder to define. The places felt better. Crime rates dropped. Traffic accidents decreased. Residents reported that their neighbourhoods felt 'more like home.'

Similar results emerged from rural sites. Fields with active shrines produced better harvests. Forests with maintained cult showed better ecological indicators. The correlation was robust; the mechanism was unknown.

One faction argued that the climate crisis was, at root, a spiritual crisis—that humanity had broken relationship with the powers of place and that only restored relationship could heal the damage. Another faction argued that this was mystification, that shrines were no substitute for emissions reductions. A third faction suggested that perhaps both were true. This faction was largely ignored, being too nuanced for the discourse.

And beneath these debates lurked the question everyone was beginning to ask. If household spirits existed, and spirits of place existed, what about the gods themselves?

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XV.

The question of the gods could not be avoided forever.

The Romans had maintained a hierarchy. *Lares* were small, local, domestic. Above them were the *genii*, spirits of lineages and places. Above them were the *di*, the gods proper—Jupiter, Mars, Minerva, the great powers whose temples had dominated the ancient world.

No one had yet attempted systematic contact with the gods. The reasons were partly practical—the protocols were unclear, the resources substantial—and partly something else. Fear, perhaps. Or the recognition that household spirits were one thing and gods were another.

The *lares* were reactive. They waited. They responded to offerings. They answered questions that were put to them. They did not, as far as anyone could tell, *want* anything—or if they wanted, they wanted only the maintenance of proper relationship, the continuation of ancient custom, the simple dignity of being acknowledged. They did not act unprompted. They did not pursue objectives. They did not, in any meaningful sense, *do* things in the world.

But the gods, in the sources, were different.

The gods had preferences. The gods had agendas. The gods intervened—in wars, in politics, in the fates of individuals and nations. They chose favourites. They punished slights. They were not, if the sources were to be believed, content merely to answer questions. They *wanted* things, and they were accustomed to *getting* what they wanted, and when they did not get what they wanted, they *acted*.

What would it mean to contact an entity like that? Not a household helper that responded to questions, but a power with its own purposes—purposes that might or might not align with human interests, that might or might not be comprehensible to human minds, that might or might not be resistible by human means?

The maximalists argued that such contact was inevitable and should be embraced. The gods, if they existed, represented capabilities far beyond the *lares*—capabilities that could transform civilisation, solve intractable problems, open possibilities currently unimaginable. The risks were real, but the potential rewards were greater.

The cautious argued that this was precisely the reasoning that had led to every catastrophe in human history. The gods were not tools. They were not resources. They were, if the sources were

accurate, *beings*—beings with more power than humans and no particular reason to defer to human preferences. To contact them deliberately was to assume that humanity could control forces that humanity could not even understand.

And there were other possibilities, less comfortable to contemplate. The ancient world had known more than benevolent household spirits and great Olympian deities. The magical papyri documented entities of various dispositions. The demonological texts catalogued beings that were not friendly—some terrifying, some merely strange, some almost absurd in ways that made their potential reality more unsettling rather than less.

Scholars at the Warburg Institute had begun surveying late antique demonology, identifying entities that might, theoretically, be contactable. Some were grand and terrible. Others were peculiar. A text from the Cairo Geniza described *Alpak*, a demon that manifested as a chicken. Medieval demonologists had catalogued it with apparent seriousness. Was *Alpak* real? The question was funny right up until you remembered that the *lares* were real too, and no one had believed in them either. If household gods existed, why not demon-chickens?

A philosopher at Oxford published an essay titled 'The Lovecraft Problem,' arguing that humanity's rush toward spiritual contact reproduced precisely the dynamic of cosmic horror fiction: investigators uncovering truths that destroyed them, reaching toward entities that did not have humanity's interests at heart—and, most troublingly, entities that might reach back. Perhaps the materialist consensus of the modern age had been not an error but a mercy. A blindness that protected humanity from knowledge it could not survive.

The essay was meant as a warning. It was widely read. It did not slow anyone down.

And yet the *lares* existed, small and domestic and comparatively safe. They had been the beginning. Everyone understood that now. What came next was uncertain.

But the gods, if they were real, might not wait to be contacted. The gods might have noticed. The gods might be watching. The gods might, even now, be deciding what to do about the small creatures who had begun, after two thousand years of silence, to light the old lamps again.

* * *

XVI.

January 2026.

Vargas had returned to Oaxaca for the holidays. She sat with her grandmother in the small house where she had grown up, before the altar that her grandmother had always maintained.

The altar had not changed. It still held the same figures, the same candles, the same small offerings that Vargas remembered from childhood. What had changed was Vargas herself. She knew now what the altar meant—not symbolically, not metaphorically, but actually. The presences her grandmother had always acknowledged were present. They had been present all along.

'You knew,' Vargas said. 'All along. Everyone here did.'

Her grandmother shrugged. 'Not everyone. But many. The old ways don't stop being true just because new people stop believing them.'

'They're calling it a discovery.'

'They would.'

Through the window, Vargas could see the hills where she had played as a child. Somewhere beyond them, in facilities she would never be permitted to enter, researchers were preparing the first systematic attempts to contact powers that had not answered human calls in two thousand years. The maximalists were eager. The cautious were terrified. The *lares*—small, domestic, faithful—continued to accept offerings in millions of homes, indifferent to what their larger cousins might do.

'What do you think happens now?' Vargas asked.

Her grandmother lit a candle before the altar. The flame caught, steadied, burned with the particular quality that Vargas now knew meant presence rather than mere combustion—the quality she had noticed, without naming it, all through her childhood.

'I don't know,' her grandmother said. 'The spirits do what spirits do. We do what we do. Sometimes it works out. Sometimes it doesn't.'

'That's not very reassuring.'

'No. It isn't.'

They sat together in the candlelight. The air had that thickness Vargas remembered from the laboratory in Strathclyde—the sense of a room containing more than its visible contents. Three years of research had not diminished the strangeness. If anything, familiarity had deepened it. The more she learned about what the *lares* did, the less she understood what they *were*.

And this, she had come to think, was perhaps the point. Some things were not meant to be understood. Some things were meant to be lived with, attended to, honoured in ignorance.

Outside, the world continued its rush toward whatever was coming. The offerings piled up. The candles burned. The prayers ascended to presences that had never left but had only been forgotten.

Her grandmother murmured words in Zapotec—a prayer, or an acknowledgment, or simply a greeting to powers that had never required explanation. The words were old. The practice was old. The

presences were older than either.

Vargas closed her eyes and let herself feel what she had spent years learning to ignore: the reality of the invisible, the presence of the present, the strange and unearned gift of a universe that contained more than she had been taught to expect.

The candle burned. The room felt inhabited. The mystery remained.

And somewhere, in laboratories and temples and classified facilities around the world, humanity prepared to meet what came next.

* * *

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